

BI Strategy Framework

Your Step-by-Step Checklist for AI-Powered Business Intelligence

💡 Complete this framework in a single working session with your leadership team. Each section builds on the previous one to create a cohesive BI strategy tied directly to measurable business outcomes.

Step 1: Define Clear Business Objectives

Start with 2–3 outcomes that matter most to your business. Clear objectives prevent "dashboard sprawl" and keep investment tied to profit and growth.

Select Your Priority Outcomes

☐	Outcome Category	Specific Goal	Executive Owner
☐	Revenue Growth	<i>e.g., Improve win rates by 15%</i>	
☐	Operational Efficiency	<i>e.g., Reduce cycle time by 20%</i>	
☐	Customer Retention	<i>e.g., Reduce churn by 10%</i>	
☐	Cost Reduction	<i>e.g., Lower labor hours by 15%</i>	
☐	Risk Mitigation	<i>e.g., Improve forecast accuracy</i>	

Map Decisions to Outcomes

For each outcome above, identify the specific decision you want to improve:

Outcome	Critical Decision	Executing Team
1.	<i>e.g., Which accounts get outreach this week?</i>	
2.	<i>e.g., Where to allocate resources?</i>	
3.	<i>e.g., Which customers are at risk?</i>	

Define Success Metrics (2 KPIs per Outcome)

KPI Name	Baseline	Target	Review Cadence

Step 2: Assess Your Data Infrastructure

Your BI strategy will only be as credible as the data underneath it. Complete this inventory to identify gaps before they cause delays.

Data Source Inventory

Internal Systems

- ☐ CRM (Salesforce, HubSpot, etc.)
- ☐ ERP / Accounting

- ☐ Marketing Automation
- ☐ Inventory / Operations
- ☐ HR / Payroll
- ☐ Product Usage / Analytics
- ☐ Customer Support / Ticketing

External Sources

- ☐ Market Benchmarks
- ☐ Intent Data Providers
- ☐ Economic Indicators
- ☐ Supplier / Logistics Feeds

Integration Points

- ☐ Manual data entry locations
- ☐ Spreadsheet exports/imports
- ☐ API connections
- ☐ Data warehouse / lake

Data Quality Assessment

Pick one KPI from Step 1 and assess its data readiness:

Quality Dimension	Question	Status	Fix Required
Accuracy	Values correct at source?	☐ Yes ☐ No	
Completeness	Required fields captured?	☐ Yes ☐ No	
Timeliness	Data available for decision cadence?	☐ Yes ☐ No	
Consistency	Single definition across systems?	☐ Yes ☐ No	

Step 3: Define Tool Requirements

Tool selection should support your strategy, not define it. Rate each capability based on your specific needs.

Capability	What to Evaluate	Priority (H/M/L)	Notes
AI/ML Capability	Forecasting, anomaly detection, NL queries		
Integration Options	Connectors, APIs for your systems		
User-Friendliness	Self-serve without breaking governance		
Scalability	Add sources, metrics, business units		
Security	Access controls, logging, data lineage		

Build vs. Buy Decision

Buy When...	Build When...
☐ Standard reporting needs ☐ Common integrations ☐ Need governed metrics ☐ Limited technical staff ☐ Faster time-to-value priority	☐ Highly specialized data model ☐ Unique workflows ☐ Proprietary analytics = competitive advantage ☐ Strong technical team ☐ Long-term customization needs
Our Decision: ☐ Buy ☐ Build ☐ Hybrid	Rationale:

Step 4: Establish Governance

Governance keeps your BI strategy reliable as you scale. Define ownership and controls upfront.

Data Domain Ownership

Data Domain	Owner	Steward (Day-to-Day)
Customer Data		
Product Data		
Financial Data		
Operations Data		
Marketing Data		

AI Governance Checklist

- ☐ Common metrics dictionary created (definitions, formulas, inclusion rules)
- ☐ Role-based access controls defined
- ☐ Approval path for new metrics established
- ☐ Data lineage documented
- ☐ Bias prevention: Training data validated, outcome monitoring in place
- ☐ Transparency: Assumptions, thresholds, and model limitations documented
- ☐ Compliance: GDPR alignment verified, contractual obligations reviewed
- ☐ Human oversight: AI outputs treated as decision support, not decision authority

Step 5: Define ROI Measurement

If you can't quantify impact, you can't defend expansion. Define how you'll measure success.

ROI Category	How We'll Measure	Expected Value
Margin Improvement	<i>e.g., Gross margin % change</i>	
Time Saved	<i>e.g., Hours/week on reporting</i>	
Churn Reduction	<i>e.g., Customer retention rate</i>	
Conversion Improvement	<i>e.g., Lead-to-close rate</i>	
Other		

Next Steps

After completing this framework:

1. Schedule a quarterly strategy review to measure progress
2. Identify quick wins that can demonstrate ROI within 90 days
3. Assign action items with owners and deadlines
4. Consider a BI strategy consultation to accelerate implementation

Ready to move from framework to execution? [Contact SWiM AI at swimsolutions.ai](https://swimsolutions.ai)